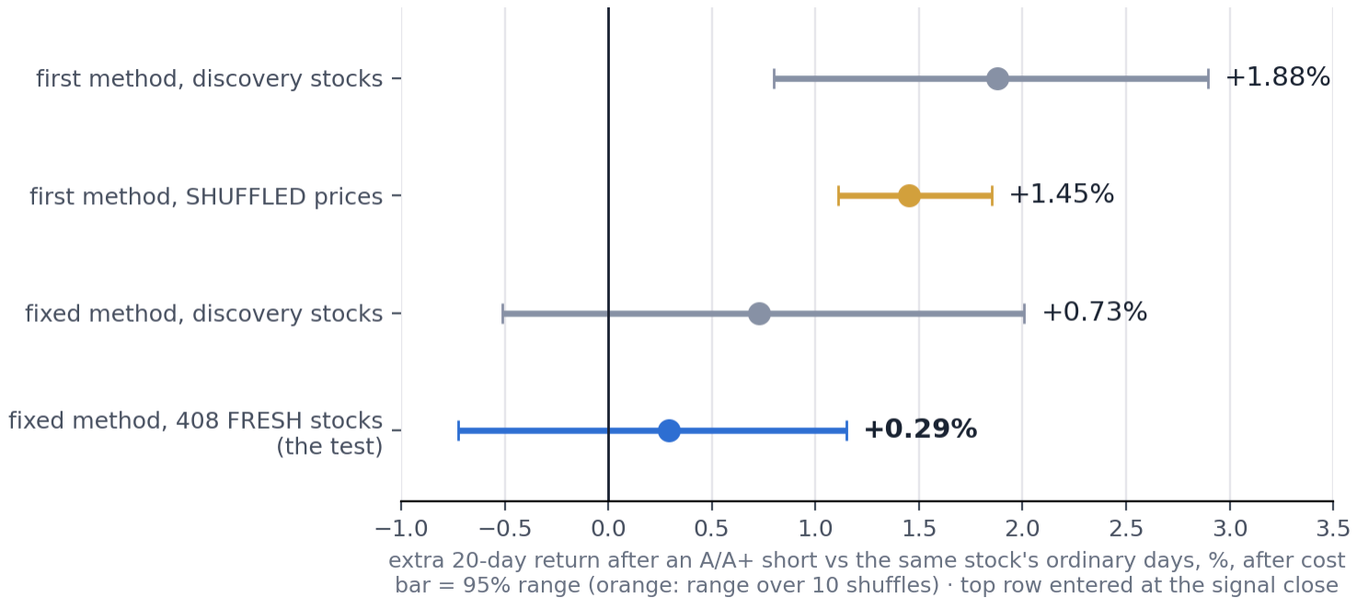
An indicator its user trusted, tested by agents that couldn't bend the rules

signal-audit · a case study in agent-governed research · Anupam Patil · 2026-10-17 · github.com/jarvisss007/signal-audit · research and engineering, not investment advice

1. **The claim.** "IE Pro", a TradingView indicator, grades its buy/sell labels A+, A or B, and its user trusted the A labels. Agents ran it on TradingView's own engine, headless, and scored 7,476 daily A labels on 153 symbols, 2002–2026.
2. **First answer: no.** A labels reach their target before their stop no more often than an ordinary day of the same stock. NOT SUPPORTED, both directions.
3. **A second idea looked real, and wasn't.** "Stocks bounce after an A short" scored +1.88% on the first method (entered at the signal close). A reviewer agent ran that method on shuffled prices, where there is nothing to find, and it still found +1.45%. The yardstick made the "yes".
4. **Fixed, frozen, run once on 408 fresh S&P 500 stocks:** +0.29%, 95% range –0.72% to +1.15%. NOT SUPPORTED. The holdout is used up and the research line is closed, as the written plan said it would be.
5. **The fix is tested, not assumed.** On 25 synthetic worlds with no edge, the old yardstick said "SUPPORTED" 9 times; the fixed one 0 times. With a real edge planted, the fixed one found it 24 times in 25.
6. **Mistakes are corrected in the open.** The test was registered before it ran (trial 56 in the ledger); earlier runs that were never entered are disclosed there, not back-filled; the first study's "worse than a random day" claim was withdrawn by an appended correction, not an edit.

> **Why this is in a portfolio:** the null result is not the point. The loop is: agents doing real work, rules enforced in code rather than in prompts, a second agent whose only job is to find what the first got wrong, and a human who decides at the gates. Swap "indicator" for "model", "pricing rule" or "dispatch policy" and the loop is the same.

The same question, four ways



The loop

Idea · found in 18 looks at old data; the 18 are recorded with it as its "mining tax"

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Written plan · rule, yardstick and pass/fail rule fixed before any result

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Reviewer agent · no edit tools, barred from the test data · "NOT READY, 7 fixes" → plan rewritten

▼

Freeze · fingerprints (SHA-256) of 5 files, all checked again before scoring

▼

Score once · placebo gate in code voids a biased yardstick

▼

Ledger · append-only; a test is a trial, a result is not; gaps disclosed, not back-filled

▼

Owner decides · go-ahead before the test; what follows after it

Two bugs that looked like an edge

Bug	Fake result	After the fix
Yardstick moved with the signal. Labels follow a fall; comparing with the same stock's same calendar year drags the yardstick down.	**+1.45% on shuffled prices**	**+0.19% on the same shuffled prices (whole-history yardstick)**
The stop was further away. Labels print on bars that close at an extreme: stop 1.46 ATR away vs 0.89 on an ordinary day, target fixed.	**+7.8 pts "hit rate edge"**	**–0.9 pts [–3.3, +1.4] at the same stop distance**
Same stop bug, synthetic data with no edge	**+8.3 pts**	**-0.2 pts [-4.1, +3.5]**

Testing the tester (25 synthetic worlds each)

	old yardstick	fixed yardstick
No edge exists: falsely "SUPPORTED"	**9 of 25**	**0 of 25**
Mean result when there is nothing	**+0.91%**	**-0.08%**
+2.5% edge planted: found	25 of 25 (+3.03%, inflated)	**24 of 25 (+2.19%)**

A test whose whole 95% range must clear zero false-alarms about once in 40. A third world, where every sharp fall partly reverses, passes the first question and is then correctly told the label adds nothing beyond the fall.

Who did what

Role	What it is	What keeps it honest
Orchestrator	Claude Code session running the research end to end	Works only from the written plan; a change after the freeze must be a new registered test
Engine runner	Computes the indicator on TradingView's servers in a hidden chart session	Read-only; parity check first (70 of 70 labels reproduced); the user's own chart is never touched
Reviewer	Subagent with no file-editing tools and an adversarial brief	Told not to open the test data while it was collected, and reported it never did; returns a verdict and fixes, never edits
Scorer + ledger	Python; pass/fail rule and placebo gate are code	Ran only after the hashes checked out; the repo's version also refuses changed files, re-registrations and edited history on its own
Owner	Anupam	Approves the test before it runs; decides what follows

- **In the repo:** the scorer, placebo gate, freeze check and ledger, generalised to any price + signal CSV; a small synthetic dataset; a one-minute demo; 10 tests; the reviewer's full report; aggregate results of the real study.
- **Kept out:** all market data and per-stock output (TradingView data, personal-use licence), the indicator's code, the headless runner, and any trading or account information. The Firm is a paper-only research operation; nothing here trades.
- **Limits:** the 408 stocks replicate across stocks, not time (their labels span the same years, 2000–2026); they are today's S&P 500 members, which favours a buy-after-a-fall rule, and it failed anyway; prices split- but not dividend-adjusted on both sides.